the group being able to 'keep its supply lines open.'[21] A source inside the organization admitted as much, saying the government decided not to ban JuD after the group agreed to keep a low profile 'in line with Pakistan's needs.'[22] Open source accounts support the assertion that Lashkar's willingness to remain India-centric, stay low-key and calibrate its activities in the Kashmir jihad in accordance with ISI direction enabled it to survive the new round of bans.[23] The ISI also reportedly gave Saeed a substantial amount of money in the form of 'severance pay' for agreeing to temper Lashkar's activities in accordance with official directives.[24]

In December 2003 militants from a coterie of outfits, along with rogue members of the Pakistani military, made two attempts on Musharraf's life within the span of a fortnight. Details of the attacks are discussed in the final section of this book. Relevant here is the degree to which the government had lost control over many of its former proxies as well as elements within the armed forces by this time. Several weeks after he escaped assassination, Musharraf met Indian Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee who visited Islamabad in January to attend the seven-nation South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation summit. At what was intended to be only a courtesy visit with Musharraf, the two men agreed to begin a new round of formal negotiations geared toward achieving peace between their countries. To this end India and Pakistan initiated a composite dialogue process [hereafter the composite dialogue] to settle bilateral issues between them. Afterwards, Musharraf pledged 'not [to] permit any territory under Pakistan's control to be used to support terrorism in any manner.'[25] This was a step beyond his declamation in 2002 when he banned Lashkar, Jaish and others, since the words 'any territory under Pakistan's control' also included Pakistan-administered Kashmir.

Pakistan attempted to demobilize some militants as a means of thinning their ranks in accordance with the country's needs, while others were kept in reserve. By early 2004 many jihadi leaders in Muzaffarabad were 'idling away their time in their, almost empty, offices.' Yet some outfits remained active. According to one HuJI commander, 'Lashkar-e-Taiba, Hizb-ul-Mujahideen and some other [smaller] groups are still busy with their business as usual. But on a smaller scale, and these are being imposed on us as the role models.'[26] Lashkar was not only far more active in Indian-administered Kashmir than any other Pakistani militant outfit by this time,